Unit 2 — Growing Up

Track E · Klasse 7 · Niveau E

Niveau E

1. Vocabulary

Match each item to its meaning or use it in a sentence.

Term	Your note
short (1 syll.)	
ending -y	
2+ syll.	
irregular	

2. Reading

Read the text and use it for the activities below.

Reading text — *Ben's Jacket*

When Ben turned twelve, he stopped fitting his old jacket. The sleeves used to cover his hands; now they ended above his wrists. His mother laughed and said, "I didn't see this coming." The strange thing was that nothing else in the house had changed: the kitchen table, the loud fridge, the cat asleep on the radiator. Only Ben was different. He used to like the jacket because the pockets were enormous. He still liked the pockets. But now they sat too high on his ribs to be useful.

Aisha said the same thing happened to her shoes. They used to feel like boats. Now they felt like sleeping bags two sizes too small. "Maybe we should swap," Ben said. "I'll take your old shoes; you take my old jacket." Aisha frowned. "We are not the same shape, Ben."

She was right. They never were.

Quick comprehension check (oral, no points):

- What changed about Ben?
- What did **not** change in the house?
- Why does Aisha say "We are not the same shape"?

Language focus — *used to* and comparatives

Used to + base verb describes a habit or state in the past that is no longer true.

- *The sleeves used to cover his hands.* — they did, but not now.
- *Aisha used to wear short hair.* — she doesn't anymore.
- *Negative: He didn't use to like maths.* (Note: no *-d* on *use* in negatives and questions.)
- *Question: Did you use to play the recorder in primary school?*

Comparatives describe how two things or two times differ.

Adjective type	Comparative	Example
short (1 syll.)	+ *-er*	tall → taller
ending *-y*	*-ier*	happy → happier
2+ syll.	*more* + adj.	difficult → more difficult
irregular	—	good → better; bad → worse; far → farther/further

Spelling traps: *big* → *bigger* (double consonant), *nice* → *nicer* (drop final *e*), *easy* → *easier* (*y* → *i*).

Used to is **not** the same as *to be used to* + *-ing* (*"I'm used to early mornings"* = I am accustomed to). Keep them apart. We use only the past-habit *used to* in this Unit.

3. Practise

Niveau G — controlled

A. Match the past habit to the present truth.

Past (*used to*)	Present
1. Ben used to fit his old jacket.	a. Now they end above his wrists.
2. The sleeves used to cover his hands.	b. Now Ben's bedroom is full of books.
3. Ben's bedroom used to be full of toys.	c. Now it is too short.
4. Aisha used to wear small shoes.	d. Now her shoes feel small.

B. Comparative gap-fill.

5. This year, Aisha is _____ (tall) than her cousin.
6. Ben's voice is _____ (deep) than last year.
7. The walk to school feels _____ (short) on sunny days.

Niveau M — productive

C. Build a sentence with *used to*.

8. Ben / fit / his old jacket → ___
9. Aisha / have / short hair → ___
10. Ms. Reyes / live / in a different city → ___

D. Comparatives — finish the sentence with your own words.

11. My handwriting is _____ now than it was in Klasse 5.
12. The school cafeteria is _____ at lunch than at breakfast.
13. My favourite subject is _____ this year than it was last year.

4. Your turn

Writing task — *Then and Now*. Write a short personal text comparing yourself in primary school with yourself now. Use *used to* at least twice and at least two comparatives.

You may write about:

- a habit (food, sport, hobby),
- something you owned (a toy, a backpack, a piece of clothing),
- a friendship,
- a place you used to spend time in.

Niveau G — 60–80 words, three sentences with *used to* and two comparatives.
Niveau M — 100–120 words, four sentences with *used to* and three comparatives.

Sample student response (Niveau M, 116 words)

When I was in primary school, I used to ride my bike to the bakery every Saturday morning. I used to buy two pretzels: one for me and one for my brother, who is now taller than me. The bakery was closer to our old house, so the trip used to be shorter. Now we live further away and the bakery feels like a serious expedition. My bike is also smaller than it used to feel — I think the bike has stayed the same and I have grown. The pretzels are still warm and salty, though, and that part is better than ever. Some things are worth a longer ride.

Strong moves: a small concrete subject (bakery + pretzel), *used to* in three places, three comparatives (*taller*, *shorter*, *smaller*, *better*), and a closing line that holds the piece together. Improve by varying connectives (”though”, ”so”, ”but”) rather than only ”and”.

5. Further reading / listening

- BBC Learning English — *6 Minute Grammar: Used to*. https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish/english/features/6-minute-grammar
- Roald Dahl — *Boy: Tales of Childhood* (extract). A model of remembering childhood with concrete detail and gentle humour. https://www.roalddahl.com
- BBC Bitesize — *Comparative and superlative adjectives*. https://www.bbc.co.uk/bitesize/topics/zhfygdm